

The Second Treatise of the Great Seth

Codex Reference: VII,2

Translated by: Joseph A. Gibbons and Roger A. Bullard

Source: Robinson, J.M. (ed.), *The Nag Hammadi Library in English*, 3rd rev. ed. (HarperSanFrancisco, 1990), p. 362ff.

Editor's Introduction

(VII,2) Introduced by Joseph A. Gibbons. Translated by Roger A. Bullard and Joseph A. Gibbons.

The Second Treatise of the Great Seth is a revelation dialogue allegedly delivered by Jesus Christ to an audience of “perfect and incorruptible ones,” that is, gnostic believers. Apart from the title, the name Seth never occurs in the text, though perhaps Jesus Christ is meant to be identified with Seth. The treatise presents, in a brief and simple way, the true story of the Savior’s commission by the heavenly Assembly, his descent to earth, his encounter with the worldly powers and apparent crucifixion, and his return to the Pleroma. To this story of the Savior are added an exhortation to the Savior’s followers and a promise of future blessedness. As the Savior says to the gnostic believers at the close of his discourse, “Rest then with me, my fellow spirits and my brothers, for ever.”

There is no doubt that The Second Treatise of the Great Seth is a work that is both Christian and gnostic. On the one hand, Christian elements are tightly woven into the fabric of the treatise. The tractate accepts the New Testament or parts of it, and claims to be the revelation of Jesus Christ. Furthermore, the crucifixion figures prominently in the tractate; in fact, it is described in three separate scenes within the tractate. On the other hand, The Second Treatise of the Great Seth is also clearly gnostic: knowledge is the means of salvation. The God of this world is evil and ignorant, and can be identified with the God of the Old Testament; in addition, all his minions are mere counterfeits and laughingstocks. The interpretation of the crucifixion is that of the Gnostic Basilides as presented by the heresiologist Irenaeus: Simon of Cyrene is crucified in the place of the laughing Jesus.

The purpose for which The Second Treatise of the Great Seth was written is plainly polemical. The entire first part (49,10-59,18) describes the true history of Jesus Christ and emphasizes, over against orthodox Christianity, his docetic passion. The second part of the tractate (59,19-70,10) is a refutation of orthodoxy’s claim to be the true church. Despite the trials and persecutions apparently instigated by the orthodox church, by those ignorant and imitative persons “who think that they are advancing the name of Christ,” the gnostic believers will enjoy true brotherhood on earth, and bliss in the joy and union of eternal life.